



THE COD OPTIMIZATION PLAYBOOK

The exact system to maintain 90%+ delivery rates on Cash on Delivery orders in India

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PHASE 1: PRE-PURCHASE TRUST BUILDING

RTOs don't start at delivery. They start at checkout. If a customer doesn't trust your store, they order COD 'just to check' and reject on arrival.

- > **Branded packaging photos** - Show the actual box. Unboxing photos reduce surprise rejection by 30-40%.
- > **Delivery timeline on product page** - 'Delivered in 5-7 business days' right below Add to Cart.
- > **Real customer photos** - Not stock photos. Real Indian customers. Even 3-4 make a huge difference.
- > **WhatsApp chat widget** - A customer who messages before buying is 3x less likely to RTO.
- > **Clear return/exchange policy** - A visible return policy actually REDUCES returns. People feel safe.
- > **GST/business details in footer** - Signals legitimacy. Scam stores don't show GST numbers.

***Tip:** The #1 trust signal: a Track Your Order page that actually works. Use AfterShip or a Shopify tracking app. When customers see their package moving, they don't reject it.*

PHASE 2: COD-TO-PREPAID CONVERSION

Every order you convert from COD to prepaid eliminates RTO risk entirely.

1

Prepaid discount

Offer Rs.50-100 off. Frame it as 'Pay online and save Rs.100' not 'COD costs extra'. The psychology matters.

2

Show prepaid first

Make UPI/card the default selected option. COD should require one extra click.

3

Free shipping for prepaid

Charge Rs.40-60 shipping for COD, free for prepaid. This alone converts 15-20% of COD orders.

4

Faster delivery for prepaid

'Prepaid orders ship same day. COD orders ship in 2-3 business days.' Urgency + reward.

PHASE 3: THE 3-STEP CONFIRMATION FLOW

This is where most stores lose money. The order is placed but nobody confirms before shipping.

1

Instant WhatsApp (within 5 min)

Send automated message: 'Hi [Name]! Your order for [Product] has been received. Please confirm your address: [Address]. Reply YES to confirm.' If no reply in 4 hours, send reminder.

Use WATI, AiSensy, or Interakt for WhatsApp Business API. Branded number with your logo as profile pic.

2

Confirmation Call (orders above Rs.1000)

30-second call: 'Hi, this is [Brand]. Confirming your order for [Product], delivering to [Address]. Correct?' This alone cuts RTOs by 20-30% on high-value orders.

3

Shipping Notification + Tracking

'Your order is on its way! Track here: [link]. Expected delivery: [date]. Questions? WhatsApp us.' Keep them engaged during transit.

PHASE 4: DELIVERY OPTIMIZATION

- > **Auto-assign best courier per pincode** - Shiprocket/Pickrr do this based on historical delivery rates.
- > **NDR management** - When delivery fails, call within 24 hours. Most are 'not at home' - reschedule, don't auto-return.
- > **Professional packaging** - Rs.15-20 per order for branded packaging reduces rejection significantly.
- > **Thank-you card inside** - Brand name, note, QR to WhatsApp. Builds repeat purchase behaviour.

BENCHMARKS TO TRACK

Metric	Bad	Average	Target
COD to Prepaid	< 20%	30-40%	50%+
RTO Rate (COD)	> 35%	20-30%	< 15%
Overall Delivery	< 70%	75-85%	90%+
NDR Resolution	< 30%	40-50%	70%+
Confirmation Rate	< 50%	60-70%	85%+

Warning: Don't skip the confirmation flow. Most stores ship blindly and wonder why 30% comes back. 5 minutes confirming saves Rs.200-500 per returned order.

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